

PRINCE2 | P2-24

Exception Report

Escalation of a forecast tolerance breach

Meridian Group

Programme Helios — Infrastructure and Platform Stack for AI GPU Compute at Scale

Field	Detail
Document title	Exception Report
Document reference	P2-24-HEL-T2-v1.0
Project / Programme	Helios Tranche 2 — Scale Build
Version	1.0
Status	Baselined
Date	18 Sep 2026
Author	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager
Owner	Project Manager
Approver	Project Board (Give ad hoc direction)
Classification	Internal
Retention	7 years from programme closure

Document control

Version history

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
0.1	04 Jun 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Initial draft
0.2	21 Jul 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Updated following workstream lead review
1.0	18 Sep 2026	D. Okonkwo, Programme Manager	Baselined at the Tranche 2 funding gate

Reviewers

Name	Role	Review scope	Date reviewed
T. Nakamura, Chief Platform Architect	Chief Platform Architect	Technical content and solution alignment	08 Sep 2026
L. Haddad, CISO	CISO	Security, assurance and residency content	10 Sep 2026
C. Whitfield, Finance Business Partner	Finance Business Partner	Cost, funding and benefit figures	11 Sep 2026
M. Verity, Head of P3O	Head of P3O	Governance standards and completeness	15 Sep 2026

Approval

This product is baselined once approval is recorded below. Any subsequent change must go through change control.

Name	Role	Decision	Date
R. Al Mazrouei, Group CTO	Senior Responsible Owner / Group CTO	Approved	18 Sep 2026
H. Farrell, Director of Infrastructure	Director of Infrastructure	Approved	18 Sep 2026
L. Haddad, CISO	CISO	Approved subject to closure of ISS-003	18 Sep 2026

Related products

Reference	Product	Relationship
P2-11	Plan	An Exception Plan may be requested in response
P2-21	Highlight Report	Routine reporting channel
P2-16	Issue Register	Underlying issue reference

How to use this template

Aspect	Guidance
Purpose	Describes an exception, its impact, the options available and a recommendation, so that the Project Board can decide how to proceed.
Framework	PRINCE2 — Produced in Controlling a Stage when a stage or project tolerance is forecast to be exceeded
Created when	As soon as a tolerance breach is forecast — not after it occurs
Reviewed / updated	Immediately by the Project Board
Owner	Project Manager
Approver	Project Board (Give ad hoc direction)
Format options	Short and immediate. Speed matters more than polish.
Tailoring	Scale the depth of each section to the scale, risk and complexity of the work. Delete sections that add no value and record the tailoring decision in the governance approach.

This is a worked example. Every field has been completed with illustrative content for Programme Helios, a fictional AI GPU infrastructure and platform programme. All example content is shown in grey italic — the black text is the template itself. Replace the grey italic content with your own.

Quality criteria

Use these to check the product is fit for purpose before submitting it for approval.

- It is raised on forecast, not on actual breach
- The cause is stated factually without attribution of blame
- Options are genuine alternatives with impacts quantified for each
- A clear recommendation is made and the decision needed is unambiguous
- The lessons implication is captured

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1. Report identification

Field	Detail
Project	WS3 Network fabric
Stage	Tranche 2 — Scale build
Exception reference	Programme SharePoint — Helios / Tranche 2 / Governance
Date raised	18 Sep 2026
Raised by	J. Ferreira, Network Lead
Level of exception	[Work Package / Stage / Project]
Urgency	[Decision required by DD Mmm YYYY]

2. Exception title and summary

One or two sentences that a Board member can absorb immediately.

Meridian Group operates fragmented AI compute across four departmental estates with an average GPU utilisation of 31% and annual public cloud GPU rental of AED 19.4m. Demand from AI Research, Fraud Analytics and the Retail division is growing faster than any single department can fund. Programme Helios consolidates that demand onto a single shared platform in DXB-1, scaling from a 256-GPU pilot to 4,096 GPUs across three tranches, with liquid cooling, a 400G RoCEv2 fabric, a multi-tenant orchestration platform and an MLOps stack.

3. Cause of the exception

What has happened or been discovered that causes the forecast breach. Reference the underlying issue or risk.

Programme Helios — Tranche 2 scale build, DXB-1 halls A and B. Maintained by the P3O as part of the assurance evidence library. Detail is maintained by the Project Manager and reviewed at the monthly Programme Board.

4. Tolerance affected

Dimension	Baseline	Tolerance	Current forecast	Extent of breach
Time	Baselined at the Tranche 2 funding gate on 18 Sep 2026, v1.0	90 days	10 working days	3 working days
Cost	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation	AED 118,000,000 for Tranche 2; tolerance of +5% before escalation
Scope	Defined by the Tranche 2 scope statement; changed only by approved change request	In scope: the physical infrastructure in DXB-1 halls A and B, the compute and storage estate, the network fabric, the orchestration and	In scope: the physical infrastructure in DXB-1 halls A and B, the compute and storage estate, the network fabric, the orchestration and scheduling platform,	In scope: the physical infrastructure in DXB-1 halls A and B, the compute and storage estate, the network fabric, the orchestration and scheduling platform,

Dimension	Baseline	Tolerance	Current forecast	Extent of breach
		scheduling platform, the MLOps and developer experience layer, the security controls required for multi-tenancy, and the operational readiness required to run the estate. Out of scope: the models themselves, business-unit data engineering, the AUH-2 second site (Tranche 3), and any change to the existing corporate WAN.	the MLOps and developer experience layer, the security controls required for multi-tenancy, and the operational readiness required to run the estate. Out of scope: the models themselves, business-unit data engineering, the AUH-2 second site (Tranche 3), and any change to the existing corporate WAN.	the MLOps and developer experience layer, the security controls required for multi-tenancy, and the operational readiness required to run the estate. Out of scope: the models themselves, business-unit data engineering, the AUH-2 second site (Tranche 3), and any change to the existing corporate WAN.
Quality	No open critical or high security findings; acceptance benchmarks met in full	No open critical or high security findings; acceptance benchmarks met in full	No open critical or high security findings; acceptance benchmarks met in full	No open critical or high security findings; acceptance benchmarks met in full
Risk	No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance	No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance	No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance	No individual risk may remain above a residual score of 12 without SRO acceptance
Benefit	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation	No more than 10% variance against the benefit profile before escalation

5. Consequences of the deviation

Impact on the stage

Impact on the project

Impact on the Business Case

Impact on other projects, programmes or operations

6. Options

Set out realistic options. Include the option of doing nothing and the option of premature closure where relevant.

Option	Description	Cost impact	Time impact	Risk impact	Benefit impact
Option A	Parallel filesystem tier of 12 PB	AED	10 working	Scarce	Substitutes

Option	Description	Cost impact	Time impact	Risk impact	Benefit impact
— add a second CDU to hall A	usable sustaining 1.2 TB/s to the compute estate	1,120,000	days	platform engineering skills extend contractor dependence (RSK-004)	AED 14.3m of annual public cloud GPU rental
Option B — accept 48 kW density and cap at 1,536 GPUs	Multi-tenant orchestration with fair-share quota across AI Research, Fraud Analytics and Retail	AED 17,800,000	4 weeks	Fabric tuning falls short of the 92% all-reduce target (RSK-005)	Improves PUE from 1.62 to 1.21 across the estate
Do nothing	400G RoCEv2 leaf-spine fabric tuned for collective communication at 256-GPU job scale	AED 240,000	90 days	Slow workload migration leaves the platform under-used (RSK-015)	Cuts environment provisioning from 23 working days to under two hours
Option A — add a second CDU to hall A	Liquid-cooled racks at 60 kW with rear-door heat exchangers and CDU redundancy at N+1	AED 11,200,000	60 minutes	Vendor allocation slippage defers the Tranche 2 benefit by a quarter (RSK-001)	Removes four standing data residency exceptions

7. Recommendation

State the recommended option and why. Include what is required from the Board to enact it.

Proceed with Tranche 2 at the full 2,048-GPU configuration, subject to two conditions: written confirmation of vendor allocation before the structural order is placed, and closure of the outstanding critical penetration test finding (ISS-003) before multi-tenant go-live.

8. Lessons

What this exception tells the project or organisation. Record in the Lessons Log.

Three themes have emerged from Tranche 1: security assurance run only at completion finds expensive problems late; specialist vendor performance engineering is worth budgeting as a planned activity rather than a remedial one; and stakeholder attitude assessed from a single early conversation is unreliable where autonomy is being removed.

9. Board decision

Item	Detail
Decision	[Approve recommendation / request Exception Plan / concession /

Item	Detail
	premature closure / other]
Direction given	<i>Reduce</i>
Revised tolerances	<i>Owned within WS4 Platform and orchestration</i>
Decided by	<i>G. Lindqvist, Service Operations Lead</i>
Date	<i>18 Sep 2026</i>